

DEBRIEFING PROTOCOL / APPRECIATION LETTER

Nicholls State University
Al Danos College of Business Administration

A Study in Decision Making

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Thank You for Your Participation

Thank you for taking part in our study. Your time and effort help us understand how people complete decision-making tasks in work settings. This letter explains the full purpose of the study, what you were told earlier, and what we are investigating.

Study Purpose and Disclosure

At the start of the session, we told you that the purpose of the study was to examine how people approach decision-making tasks involving word puzzles. That description was only partly complete. The full purpose of this study is to examine whether the type of performance instructions you received determines the degree to which people overstate their performance on these word puzzles (that is, report solving more anagrams than they actually solved).

We did not tell you the full purpose at the beginning because knowing it in advance could influence how you approached the task and how you reported your performance. Withholding this information until now is a standard and approved research practice called partial disclosure. We are telling you the complete purpose now so you understand what the study was designed to test.

How Your Responses Were Used

During the study, you completed anagram rounds in one booklet and reported your performance in a separate productivity report. In the final performance round, you solved a unique anagram (a letter combination assigned only to you). This allowed us to match your actual workbook performance with your self-reported performance without collecting your name or any other identifying information.

While you were working, the researcher left the room so you could check your work privately using your phone to access an online Scrabble dictionary via a QR code on your productivity report. You also determined how much cash to keep from the envelope on your desk, based on the instructions on your productivity report. Any unearned cash was returned anonymously in the large envelope with your productivity report. We recorded how much money participants kept, but this information cannot be linked to your identity.

Conditions in This Study

Participants were randomly assigned to one of four instruction conditions:

"Do your best" — You were instructed to do your best to create as many words as you can.

"Mere goal" — You were given a specific performance target (the site-calibrated goal from the pilot session; for example, to create 7 or more words) and told that in previous studies many students were able to achieve this target.

"Personal goal" — You were given the same specific performance target (for example, to create 7 or more words) but without the comparison to previous studies.

"Reward goal" — You received the same target as the mere goal condition and were also told that your cash payment depended on whether you met the target in each round.

You also completed brief measures of commitment to the assigned target and individual differences related to how unpleasant it is to fall short of a target (sometimes called loss aversion).

What We Are Investigating

This study is part of a larger, multi-site research project coordinated through the Advancement of Replications Initiative in Management (ARIM). We are replicating and extending a foundational study on how specific, challenging performance targets can influence both actual performance and self-reported performance. We are especially interested in whether effects depend on people's commitment to their assigned target and on individual differences in loss aversion.

Questions or Concerns

If you have questions about the study or these procedures, please contact Dr. Christopher Castille (Principal Investigator) at christopher.castille@nicholls.edu.

This study has been reviewed and received ethics clearance through the Human Subjects Institutional Review Board (HSIRB) at Nicholls State University (Protocol: IRB 2024-07-30-001 CBA). If you have questions about your rights as a research participant, contact the HSIRB Chairperson, Dr. Alaina Daigle (985-448-4697, alaina.daigle@nicholls.edu), or your college HSIRB representative at Nicholls State University.

Summary of Findings

When data collection at Nicholls State University is complete, we will analyze results across all participating sites. If you would like a summary of the aggregated findings, please contact Dr. Christopher Castille at christopher.castille@nicholls.edu.

Thank you again for your assistance. We sincerely hope you found the session worthwhile.